

What it Takes to be an Open Source Expert

OSFY speaks to industry leaders to bring you their thoughts on this hot topic...



While open source gradually exerts its control over almost every aspect of technology, it has emerged as a clear profit earner for businesses and has helped them move up the value chain. As open source adoption increases across the globe, the need for a multi-skilled workforce becomes important to sustain this trend. Driven by this need, enterprises today are looking for talent with the advanced skills to cope up with their business objectives. Needless to say, the demand for open source professionals has increased manifold in the last few years. According to the 2013 Linux Jobs Report brought out by the Linux Foundation, almost 90 per cent of employers are planning to hire open source experts in the next few months. The report also indicates that there is a yawning gap between the demand and supply of FOSS professionals and open source talent is not easy to find. So, what goes into the making of an open source expert? *OSFY* got in touch with industry leaders and members of Linux User Groups to seek answers to this question.

The 3 Cs required to succeed

If you wish to flex your muscles in the open source circuits and become a pro, there are three Cs that will help you in your endeavour—curiosity, commitment and community. Shares Divyanshu Verma, Engineering Manager, Linux Engineering at Dell R&D, India, “To become a FOSS expert,

the first thing one needs is to be curious and committed. FOSS allows everyone and anyone to learn and program, without donning any corporate hat or a badge, and then, they subsequently contribute code back to the community. FOSS experts are supposedly good at working in a virtual world. They need to be self-motivated to comprehend problems and provide solutions that are accepted by the open source community. Given the wide acceptance of the open source paradigm, companies such as Google, IBM, HP, Dell, Broadcom, Cisco, and Intel, now motivate their employees to work on FOSS projects and contribute code freely to the community.”

Sankarshan Mukhopadhyay, an active member of the Chennai Linux Users Group, voices similar views. “In his book ‘Outliers’ (<[<http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Outliers_\(book\)>](http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Outliers_(book))), Malcolm Gladwell proposed the 10,000 hour rule, claiming that the key to success in any field is, to a large extent, a matter of practising a specific task for a total of around 10,000 hours. However, to aspire to be an expert, one needs to take the first step towards that goal. So, it requires that first step of contributing to an open source project and participating in an open source community to be set towards becoming an expert,” says he. Citing another example, Mukhopadhyay says writer Karl Fogel has a reasonably interesting book (<http://producingoss.com/en/index.html>), which mentions what one needs to get familiar with prior to contributing to open source